

THE WOLF

Lupus



SIZE RANKING 46

BRIGHTEST STAR

Alpha (α) 2.3

GENITIVE Lupi

ABBREVIATION Lup

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
May–JuneFULLY VISIBLE
34°N–90°S

Lupus is a southern constellation lying on the edge of the Milky Way between the better-known figures of Centaurus and Scorpius. It contains numerous double stars of interest to amateur observers.

It was one of the original 48 constellations familiar to the ancient Greeks, who visualized it as a wild animal speared by Centaurus (see panel, below).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

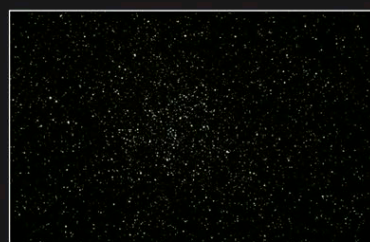
Kappa (κ) Lupi, with components of magnitudes 3.9 and 5.7, and Xi (ξ) Lupi, with components of magnitudes 5.1 and 5.6, are two doubles that are easy to spot through a small telescope.

Pi (π) Lupi can be divided into matching 5th-magnitude components through a telescope with an aperture of 3 in (75 mm). Even more challenging is 4th-magnitude Mu (μ) Lupi, which has a wide

7th-magnitude companion visible through a small telescope. Its primary star, however, is a close double, needing an aperture of at least 4 in (100 mm) to separate.

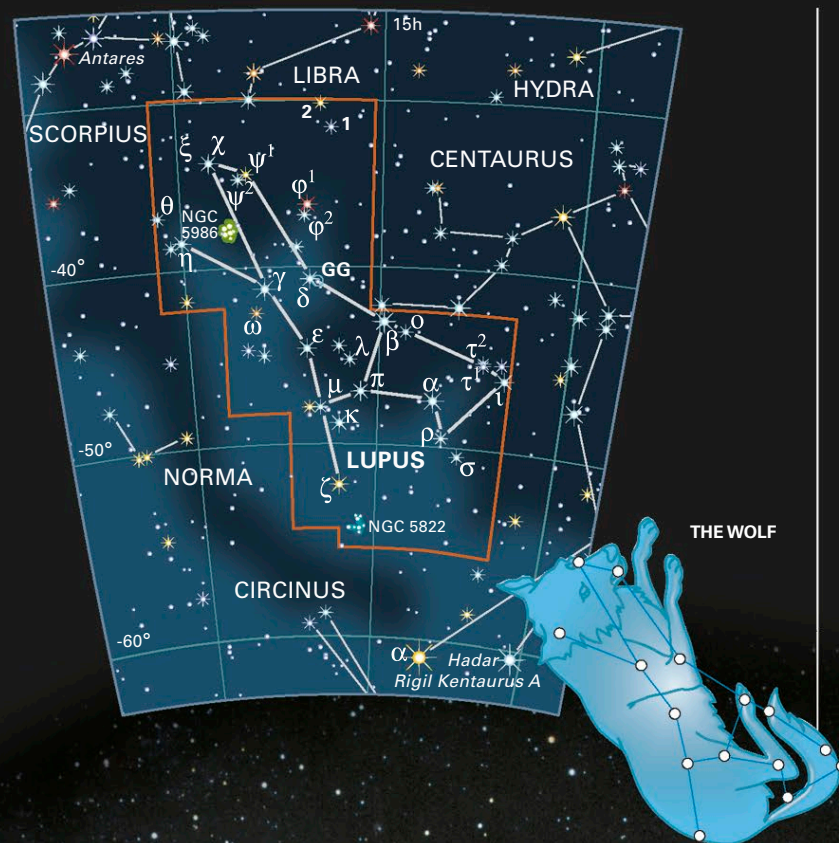
The 3rd-magnitude Epsilon (ϵ) Lupi has a companion of 9th magnitude, and Eta (η) Lupi is a 3rd-magnitude star with an 8th-magnitude companion.

NGC 5822 is a rich open cluster within the Milky Way. Its brightest stars are of only 9th magnitude, so it is not particularly prominent. It lies 2,400 light-years away.



NGC 5822

This large open cluster in southern Lupus contains more than 100 stars of 9th magnitude and fainter. It can be seen through binoculars or a small telescope.



THE WOLF

MYTHS AND STORIES

THE LANCED BEAST

To the ancient Greeks and Romans, Lupus represented a wild animal of unspecified nature that had been speared, by neighboring Centaurus, on a long pole called a thyrsus. In consequence, Centaurus and Lupus were often regarded as a combined figure. The identification of Lupus as a wolf seems to have become common during Renaissance times.

IN MIRROR IMAGE

This medieval Arabic illustration shows Centaurus holding Lupus and the thyrsus, which has become a bunch of leaves or flowers.



BESTIAL OFFERING

Here, Lupus is partly surrounded by the stars of Centaurus. In Greek myth, the centaur killed the beast and carried it to the altar, Ara.